
2.7 Unit 2, Option E: Britain in the Later 20th Century: Responding to Change

Focus

Grounded in an understanding of the relevant chronology, this option concentrates on key developments in the political, social and cultural development of Britain in the second half of the 20th century, with a particular emphasis on understanding in some depth the key issues that challenged Labour and Conservative politicians, including the extent of consensus between them, why consensus was fractured and with what consequences. It also gives students the opportunity to understand key cultural developments in the second half of the century, including the developments that challenged existing perspectives, attitudes and beliefs.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in Appendix 1.

Students entered for Option E are required to study ONE topic: E1 or E2.

E1 British Political History, 1945-90: Consensus and Conflict

- The Labour election victory of 1945: reasons for it and key features of domestic policy of Labour governments of 1945-51; extent to which this was 'an age of austerity'.
- The Conservative governments of 1951-64: extent of continuity with Labour objectives; key features of domestic policy (economic management, housing, unemployment); rising living standards.
- Labour and Conservative governments, 1964-79: reasons for growing domestic problems (inflation, wages policy, relations with trade unions).
- The Conservative election victory of 1979: reasons for it and key features of the domestic policy of Thatcher governments; domestic achievements; reasons why the Thatcher era was controversial; reasons for her fall in 1990.

E2 Mass Media, Popular Culture and Social Change In Britain since 1945

- The role of newspapers, radio, cinema and television in society since 1945; the relationship between mass media and changes in attitudes and values in British society.
- The impact of the mass media on British society: investigative journalism and its consequences; the impact of satire; privacy and individual rights; 'celebrity culture'; challenges to authority and authority figures.
- Popular and youth culture from the mid-1950s: its growing importance and its impact on society; significance of the US in changing leisure patterns; the relationship between 'elite' and 'popular' culture.
- Electronic technology and its impact: the internet and the worldwide web; information highways; implications for patterns of work and leisure; changing relationship between individuals and society.